understanding, he was fabricating the ISRO spy case, ostensibly on someone's orders.

That the IB was penetrated by the US became clear when Dhar's colleague Ratan Sehgal was sacked as the IB joint director and charges of having nine 'unauthorized and clandestine' meetings with CIA station chief in Delhi, Timoty Long, and his deputy Susan Brown between 19 September and 31 October 1996. The investigation found that the meetings happened in Sehgal's house in Bharati Nagar and in the parking lot of Ambassador Hotel, both in Delhi. Counter intelligence officers reported evidence of Sehgal having received a 'large packet' from Ms August, a former deputy station chief of the CIA, outside Ambassador Hotel.

Sehgal was asked to face prosecution or put in his papers. He chose voluntary retirement. It is strange that the ISRO spy case started a few months after Sehgal joined the IB from the Ministry of External Affairs and ended around the same time he was chucked out of the IB.

Another interesting coincidence is that R B Sreekumar, Deputy Director, IB, Kerala unit, happened to be the CISF commandant in charge of security of ISRO's VSSC campus in Trivandrum many years earlier. It was only after my arrest, I realised that I had given enough reasons to Sreekumar to hate me. Here is one of our past encounters.

I had seen Sreekumar on the VSSC campus a few times, he came across as a silent officer doing his duty. He reported to P M Nair, the administrative head, who in turn reported to Gowarikar. There was no scope for much interaction between me and Sreekumar. VSSC was to recruit some mechanical engineers, and I was in the selection committee when one day Sreekumar walked into my room. He had a request to favourably consider the candidature of a woman. Going by selection guidelines, those who come with recommendations should be removed from the candidate list and should not be considered for the interview.

I did not follow this guideline since that may deny the job to a deserving candidate just because someone had come with a recommendation for him/her, sometimes without his/her knowledge. During such recruitment phases it was common for me to receive calls from ministers' offices and